he fell out with the Indian government, was accused of subversive activities, removed from power and spent several spells in jail or exiled from the state between the years 1953 and 1972.

However, in 1975, during the Emergency, the then prime minister Indira Gandhi reached an accord with Abdullah where, in return for him agreeing to give up his demand for self-determination, he would be allowed to re-enter politics and contest in the state elections. Experts saw it as the biggest sign of the completion of Kashmir's accession to India. In retaliation, Pakistan, smarting under its humiliating defeat in the Bangladesh War, began nurturing major extremist groups to foment trouble in Kashmir. The proxy war India's pernicious neighbour would embark upon would subsequently play a role in the exodus of the Kashmiri Pandits.

Fast forward to 1984, which was a watershed year both for J&K and the nation in many ways. After Sheikh Abdullah's death in 1982, his son and political heir, Farooq Abdullah,

**The tide turned when militants got five of their men released in exchange for Rubaiya. India's weak-kneed response pushed them to go in for the kill**

took over as chief minister and won the 1983 election with a comfortable majority. A year later, however, Maqbool Bhat, a Kashmiri insurgent, was executed in February. This resulted in a spurt of support for extremism in the Valley. To keep Farooq in check, Indira appointed Jagmohan, a tough, no-nonsense task-master, as J&K governor. In July, Mrs Gandhi, upset that Farooq had spurned an alliance with the Congress, effected a vertical split in his party, the National Conference, and had his brother-in-law G.M. Shah take over as chief minister. Within months of that move, she was assassinated in October by her Sikh bodyguards, triggering a wave of violence against Sikhs in Delhi and other parts of the country.

## WHO IS TO BLAME?

When Rajiv Gandhi swept to power on the back of a sympathy wave in the 1984 general election, which the Congress won with a brute majority, he focused largely on dealing with Punjab, which was proving to be the foremost internal security threat at the time. This gave Pakistan's premier spy agency, the Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), the space to start fomenting trouble in Kashmir. A senior Indian intel-



Rakesh Bhat with his wife Meenakshi and son Krishna

MILIND SHELTE

## RAKESH BHAT, 43

***Now living in Navi Mumbai;***
original resident of Fateh Kadal, Srinagar
***Fled the Valley in March 1990***

A window in Rakesh Bhat's house in Fateh Kadal, Srinagar, overlooked a BSF post. It offered a spectacular view of the Jhelum, but also of terrorists opening fire and throwing grenades at the BSF post.

"I grew up in the shadow of terror," Bhat, now 43 and living in Navi Mumbai, recalls. In Srinagar, Bhat lived with his father Hridaynath, mother Sarla and younger brother Rohit. The situation, he says, grew worse towards the end of 1989 when loudspeakers from nearby mosques started blaring slogans like '*Kashmir banega Pakistan. Batav Rostuy, Batenien Saan* (Kashmir will become Pakistan. Without Pandit men but with Pandit women)'.

In March 1990, they left. "All we had was Rs 2,300 that my father was carrying," says Bhat. Initially, they stayed in a tent in Jammu and later rented a cattle shed-turned-home for Rs 500 a month. "We were forced to become poor," Bhat says, breaking down.

In 1997, he came to Jalgaon in Maharashtra to study mechanical engineering as the then BJP-Shiv Sena government had reserved two seats for Kashmiri Pandits in every engineering college. "I could settle and live comfortably in Maharashtra because of the degree," says Bhat.

These days, he is engaged in highlighting the Pandits' plight. His efforts include producing a short film titled *Exodus & Exile: The Need*, which has won 10 international awards. He has also written six plays on the subject. "The government should provide us separate lands for resettlement where we will be in majority," he says.

Bhat backs the idea of 'Panun Kashmir', a separate Union territory for Kashmiri Hindus spread across the Valley. "Mine is the last generation that wants to return. My teenage son may never want to leave Maharashtra."

**–Kiran D. Tare**